PSYCHOLOGICAL/COGNITIVE FALSE BELIEF #1 · PERSONALITY PATTERNS · MISTRUST

“If I let my guard down, people will hurt or take advantage of me.”

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Personality Disorders · Paranoid Personality Disorder
An educational example of a mistrust belief. Recognizing this belief does not establish a diagnosis. Similar beliefs can occur in many contexts.

Where it often comes from

Being betrayed, bullied, deceived, or mistreated can teach a person to stay alert. Unpredictable relationships, repeated criticism, or messages that nobody can be trusted may strengthen this expectation. These are possible learning experiences, not an explanation for every person. A protective rule can become too broad when it is applied to everyone, even when the present evidence is different.

How the belief can keep itself going

Expecting harm can lead to scanning for threats, withdrawing, testing people, or responding defensively. Those responses may reduce opportunities to learn that some relationships are dependable. The task is to compare expectations with present evidence while preserving appropriate boundaries.

What Scripture teaches

God invites us to put our trust in Him when we are afraid, rather than letting fear determine every relationship. Scripture also describes the goodness of companionship, receiving help, carrying one another’s burdens, and loving each other. These passages challenge the expectation that closeness can bring only harm. With God’s help, I can make room for people who show care and reliability, accept support, and discover that I do not have to face life alone.

> *“Trust in the LORD with all your heart, and lean not on your own understanding; in all your ways acknowledge Him, and He will make your paths straight”* **(Proverbs 3:5–6)**.

Also see

> “When I am afraid, I put my trust in You. In God, whose word I praise— in God I trust. I will not be afraid. What can man do to me?” **(Psalm 56:3–4)**.

> “Two are better than one, because they have a good return for their labor. For if one falls down, his companion can lift him up; but pity the one who falls without another to help him up!” **(Ecclesiastes 4:9–10)**.

> “Carry one another’s burdens, and in this way you will fulfill the law of Christ” **(Galatians 6:2)**.

> “This is My commandment, that you love one another as I have loved you” **(John 15:12)**.

Common self-statements

- People always have a hidden agenda.
- If someone is kind, they probably want something.

- I must watch for every sign of betrayal.
- If I relax, I will miss the danger.
- I cannot tell anyone what I really think.
- Depending on someone gives them power to hurt me.

Common logical errors

- **Overgeneralization:** Applying one person's betrayal to all people.
- **Mind reading:** Treating a guess about someone's motives as a known fact.
- **Selective attention:** Noticing signs of danger while overlooking consistent, respectful behavior.
- **Emotional reasoning:** Taking the feeling of being unsafe as proof of a present threat.
- **All-or-nothing thinking:** Assuming my only choices are complete trust or complete distrust.
- **Catastrophizing:** Predicting serious harm from an ordinary interaction without enough evidence.

Challenging questions

- What happened that I can directly observe, and what meaning have I added?
- What evidence supports my concern? What evidence points another way?
- Am I responding to this person's behavior or to an earlier betrayal?
- What are two other possible explanations?
- Has this person respected a clear boundary before?
- What small amount of trust, if any, fits the evidence?
- Can I protect myself without assuming that everyone intends harm?

Truth summary

> I can trust God with my fears and allow caring people to become part of my life. Past betrayal does not determine what every new relationship will be. Some people are dependable, and I can learn to recognize and receive their care. I can take small steps toward connection, ask for help, and let trust grow through shared experience.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Trust
- Friendship
- Love, For Others
- Help
- Fear

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Anxiety/Worry/Fear
- Communication
- Thinking, Healthy

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief



Trust in You — Lauren Daigle

An invitation to trust God even when circumstances feel uncertain.



'Tis So Sweet to Trust in Jesus — Alan Jackson · Gaither Music TV

Encourages resting in Christ's promises and learning to trust Him.



He Will Hold Me Fast — Keith & Kristyn Getty

Reassurance of Christ's faithful care when fear makes trust difficult.



I Am Not Alone — Kari Jobe

Reassures me of God's faithful presence, helping me face fear without feeling that I must handle everything alone.

Clinical background

This original educational example uses cognitive restructuring, checking interpretations, and modest behavioral experiments. It is informed by the cognitive model of personality beliefs; it is not a DSM criterion, a quotation from Beck, or a validated treatment protocol.

Beck Institute: Beliefs in personality disorders · Beck, Davis, & Freeman (Eds.), Cognitive Therapy of Personality Disorders (3rd ed.)

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

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HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "If I let my guard down, people will hurt or take advantage of me"

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Read through each section and **check the one that fits you best**. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ **Date started:** _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"If I let my guard down, people will hurt or take advantage of me." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What facts do I know, and what am I assuming?
- ☐ What evidence does not fit my fear?
- ☐ What else could explain this person's behavior?
- ☐ Is an old experience shaping my expectation?
- ☐ What boundary would help me make a measured choice?
- ☐ What small step fits this person's actual track record?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ When I am afraid, I can put my trust in God.
- ☐ I do not have to face every difficulty alone.
- ☐ Some people will respond to me with kindness and care.
- ☐ I can receive help without assuming there is a hidden motive.
- ☐ Past betrayal does not mean every relationship will end in betrayal.
- ☐ I can allow trust to grow through small experiences of dependable care.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- [ ] **Proverbs 3:5–6**
  "Trust in the LORD with all your heart, and lean not on your own understanding; in all your ways acknowledge Him, and He will make your paths straight."
- [ ] **Psalm 56:3–4**
  "When I am afraid, I put my trust in You. In God, whose word I praise— in God I trust. I will not be afraid. What can man do to me?"
- [ ] **Ecclesiastes 4:9–10**
  "Two are better than one, because they have a good return for their labor. For if one falls down, his companion can lift him up; but pity the one who falls without another to help him up!"
- [ ] **Galatians 6:2**
  "Carry one another's burdens, and in this way you will fulfill the law of Christ."
- [ ] **John 15:12**
  "This is My commandment, that you love one another as I have loved you."

A verse I found myself: _____

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Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ **Make my Truth Card** (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ **Memorize my Scripture** from Step 4.
- ☐ **Listen to one song each day** from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- ☐ **Set reminders** to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ **A buzz:** my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ **An everyday event:** every time I _____
  - ☐ **A visual reminder:** something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ **Trust and support log:** Each day, record one time someone showed kindness, kept a promise, listened, or offered help. Describe what I allowed myself to receive and what I learned.
- ☐ **My name in Scripture:** Rewrite my verse with my name in it and read it aloud each morning.
  *For example, a personalized adaptation of Psalm 56:3 (based on BSB) is: "When **Sarah** is afraid, **she** puts **her** trust in You."*
- ☐ **Gratitude journal:** Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ **Truth recording:** Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ **Reading:** The "Trust" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ **Listening:** The Overcoming Anxiety audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

Choose a modest, ordinary situation. These exercises do not require revealing private information or approaching anyone who has threatened, coerced, or abused you. A respectful response is useful evidence; a boundary violation is useful evidence too.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

- ☐ **Accept one small offer of help.** Choose a person who has shown reliability. Accept ordinary help, such as help with a task, and notice what actually happens.
- ☐ **Ask someone to listen.** Tell a caring friend about a modest everyday concern and ask for a few minutes of listening. Compare their actual response with what I predicted.
- ☐ **Make room for companionship.** Invite a dependable friend to a short walk, coffee, or another comfortable shared activity. Notice moments of warmth or connection.
- ☐ **Acknowledge dependable care.** Thank someone for a specific way they have supported me. Write down how it feels to recognize and receive that care.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Review what you learned; bring this page to counseling if you are attending.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "If I let my guard down, people will hurt or take advantage of me": _____ % **My truth:** _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Care or support I received
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~If I let my guard down, people will hurt or take advantage of me.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Father, when I am afraid, help me put my trust in You. Heal the hurts that have taught me to expect betrayal. Help me recognize people who show kindness and faithfulness, receive their support, and take small steps toward friendship. Teach me to give and receive love, and remind me that I do not have to carry every burden alone. In Jesus' name, Amen.

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Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.